



FOR MORE
STORIES

— dismissively dubbed the ‘lost generation’ and ‘sandwich generation’ — were trampled by the Big Three, ambushed by the even more formidable new Big Two, or humbled by newcomers. During their small window of opportunity, only Thiem and Medvedev won a Grand Slam title, while Olympic gold medallist Zverev reached three Major finals and Tsitsipas two. “They [Sincaraz] are definitely several levels above everyone right now,” conceded Djokovic.

Later, at the U.S. Open, Sinner sailed through his first six matches, dropping a set only to a resurgent No. 27 Denis Shapovalov, a dangerous lefty slugger, in the third round, and to the much-improved No. 25 Felix Auger-Aliassime in the semifinals.

Downplaying his terrific 26-match winning streak at hard-court Majors, Sinner said: “You know I’m not a machine. I’m human. I feel tension. I feel pressure.”

In the other half of the draw, Alcaraz overwhelmed Djokovic 6-4, 7-6(4), 6-2 in the other semifinal. Before the match, he had said: “I really want revenge.” The GOAT had beaten Alcaraz in the 2024 Paris Olympics gold-medal match and again at the Australian Open in January, but avenging those setbacks was small potatoes now for the Spanish superstar.

The more important mission at Flushing Meadows was to exact revenge for arch-rival Sinner’s victory over him in the Wimbledon final. That would reward Alcaraz with his second U.S. Open and sixth Grand Slam title, regain the No. 1 ranking, and dethrone the King of Hard Courts.

In the end, Alcaraz triumphed 6-2, 3-6, 6-1, 6-4. He played his A+ game, aside from a second-set hiccup when, overconfident, he foolishly abandoned a winning pattern and fiddled with touch shots. Nevertheless, the 15th edition of this riveting rivalry will be remembered as a showcase for the genius of Alcaraz.

Sinner’s post-mortem was honest and accurate — “I was very predictable today. On court, he did many things; he changed up the game. That’s his style. Now it’s going to be on me if I want to make changes or not.”

ARYNA SABALENKA REIGNS IN A YEAR OF PARITY AT THE TOP

Will the past decade’s parity in women’s tennis continue next year or will a new superstar emerge to dominate? You can find persuasive evidence for either scenario in this exciting, unpredictable year that was.

Strong run: Aryna Sabalenka was easily the top female player of the season, reaching three finals and finishing with a U.S. Open title.

Aryna Sabalenka, who held the No. 1 ranking for the entire year, became the first woman to reach three Major finals, and the final of the WTA Finals, since Germany’s Angelique Kerber in 2016. However, the Belarusian won only one of those finals, at the U.S. Open. Meanwhile, Naomi Osaka jumped from No. 57 to No. 16, reaching the Montreal final and then defeating Coco Gauff and Karolina Muchova to make the U.S. Open semis.

Yet it was another hard-hitting veteran with a far less glittering resume who stole the show at the year’s first Major in Melbourne. Madison Keys, a teenage talent once tabbed as a future No. 1 by Serena Williams, came close to fulfilling her girlhood dream when she faced close friend Sloane Stephens in the biggest match of their lives for the coveted title at the 2017 U.S. Open. The pressure paralysed Keys. Making 17 errors in the first seven games, she self-destructed in a 6-3, 6-0 tearful debacle.

Fast forward to the 2025 Australian Open. “I’ve obviously thought of that match endlessly for the past eight years,” said Keys with a bittersweet laugh after upsetting World No. 2 Iga Swiatek in a riveting 5-7, 6-1, 7-6(8) semifinal.

Ironically, No. 19 Keys found inspiration from Sabalenka. The World No. 1 enjoyed a 4-1 dominance in their rivalry, beating her all three times on hard courts and both times at Slam events. “The one thing I really wanted to try to be better at was not playing more passive in big points and

